MINUTES OF THE CLARE COUNTY BOARD OF COMMISSIONERS

Approved 7-17-2024

225 W. Main St.
Harrison, Michigan 48625

~~Un~~approved minutes
June 12, 2024

Meeting was called to order at 9:00 a.m.

Pledge of Allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America

District 1 Marlene Housler, District 2 Dale Majewski, District 3 Samantha Pitchford, District 4 Jeff Haskell, District 5 David Hoefling, District 6 Jack Kleinhardt, District 7 Gabe Ambrozaitis, District 8 George Gilmore and District 9 Rick Fancon

COMMISSIONERS ABSENT

None

OTHERS PRESENT

Clerk & Register of Deeds Lori Mott, Administrator Lori Phelps, members of the public and zoom participants

APPROVAL OF AGENDA

It was moved by Commissioner Majewski, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to approve the agenda with one change, **motion carried.**

*Change – Under Finance and Administration, item d. Sale of property to be removed from the agenda.

APPROVAL OF MINUTES

It was moved by Commissioner Hoefling, seconded by Commissioner Housler to approve the Board of Commissioners Minutes of May 15, 2024, **motion carried.**

It was moved by Commissioner Majewski, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to approve the Committee of the Whole Minutes of June 5, 2024, **motion carried.**

It was moved by Commissioner Housler, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to approve the Closed Session Minutes of June 5, 2024, **motion carried.**

GENERAL PUBLIC COMMENT

Kim Kennicott (former Airport Manager) spoke regarding funding the airport and commended the efforts by Commissioner Ambrozaitis to improve the airport. Mr. Kennicott asked the Commissioners to fund and maintain the airport to meet FAA (Federal Aviation Administration) standards, as he indicated that the Board of Commissioners has not done in years past. Mr. Kennicott asked the Board of Commissioners to accept the free money being offered by a grant to be presented later in the meeting.

Pat Adams spoke in support of the airport and pointing out that the life flight can land there and know exactly where to go to land and meet the ambulance. Mr. Adams asked how much one life is worth to the Commissioners. Mr. Adams confirmed that communities with airports expand more than communities without an airport.

Carl Lounsbury owns one of the hangers at the airport and just signed 7-year lease and feels he is under a constant threat by the Board of Commissioners to close the airport. Hanger owners pay taxes on hangers and pay lease payments on hangers. Mr. Lounsbury pointed out that if the airport wasn't a viable asset to community MDOT (Michigan Department of Transportation) wouldn't be here putting their money into the airport. Mr. Lounsbury urged the Board of Commissioners to accept the grant being offered by MDOT later in the meeting.

GENERAL PUBLIC COMMENT - continued

Bob Ash, hanger owner, confirmed he bought property in Clare County because of the availability of the airport. Mr. Ash spoke about lights that were just donated to the airport and the cost savings by using donated used lights instead of trying to get new. Mr. Ash asked the Board of Commissioners to fund the airport and work to get minimum items repaired so more grant funding becomes available.

COMMUNICATIONS LIST

a. State Equalization Report – No discussion
b. Notice of Master Plan, Lincoln Township – No discussion
c. Notice of Farmland Development Denial – No discussion

ADMINISTRATOR'S REPORT

Administrator Lori Phelps provided the Commissioners with updates regarding the state revenue sharing, HB-5203 (re-hiring of retirees without jeopardizing their retirement) and SB-1115 Medicade coverage for inmates(allows county inmates to have their uninsured medical needs covered). Administrator Phelps has been working on the 2025 budget and is still in the negotiating stage with all 6 unions.

PUBLIC HEARINGS/SPECIAL PRESENTATIONS

1. Jim McBryde and Allison Heinrich, Middle Michigan Development Corporation
   Mr. McBryde and Ms. Heinrich presented the 2023 Annual Report for Middle Michigan Development and focused on Clare County. The most important thing they focus on is business retention and expansion. They also try to attract new businesses and community development. Community development is a challenge and they are trying to keep young people in our community.

HEALTH AND HUMAN SERVICES

1. Mid State Health Network
   It was moved by Commissioner Hoefling, seconded by Commissioner Housler to re-appoint George Gilmore to the Mid-State Health Network Substance Use Disorder Oversight Policy Board for a three-year term beginning September 1, 2024, **motion carried**.

PHYSICAL RESOURCES AND ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT

It was moved by Commissioner Gilmore, seconded by Commissioner Fancon to defund the Clare County Airport for the upcoming year. Commissioner Ambrozaitis called for a point of order citing the motion was not on the agenda. Chairman Haskell called for discussion. Commissioner Gilmore gave his opinion that the Airport is a huge drain on the county. Commissioner Ambrozaitis confirmed that since 1980 there have only been 2 appropriations, totaling $30,000.00. Commissioners Ambrozaitis and Hoefling reminded the Board of Commissioners that there are many signed hanger leases, an airport restaurant lease and 14 airport restaurant employees to consider. Commissioner Gilmore indicated the county attorney could handle breaking the leases. Commissioner Fancon offered his opinion that the airport only benefits 1-3 townships in the county and questioned what value it has brought to Clare County.

PHYSICAL RESOURCES AND ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT - continued

Commissioner Ambrozaitis confirmed that the Clare County Airport has been in existence for 88 years and the current Airport Committee has set forth a plan, for the first time ever, to improve the airport with donated items from other airports and grant money from the State of Michigan. Commissioner Ambrozaitis pointed out that at this point, when improvements are being made and a plan is in place, Commissioners Gilmore and Fancon presented a motion to defund and airport with plans of closing it. There have been communication with investors to build new hangers in an effort to start businesses in Clare County, but investors don't want to build if there are threats of breaking leases and closing the airport. Commissioner Ambrozaitis confirmed one hanger was just purchased with the intent of opening an aviation related business.

Chairman Haskell pointed out that the 2025 budget has not been presented or approved and believes that a motion to defund something that has not been funded is premature and asked Commissioner Gilmore to rescind his motion. Commissioner Gilmore and Commissioner Fancon agreed to withdraw their motion and have this issue put on the agenda for the Committee of the Whole.

Recess at 10:49 a.m.
Back in session at 10:55 a.m.

1. Airport
   It was moved by Commissioner Pitchford, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to approve a 5% increase in the yearly hangar lease rates as allowed in the current lease agreements effective July 1, 2024, through June 30, 2025 from $280.78 per year to $294.82 per year as recommended by the Airport Committee, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (9) being Commissioners Pitchford, Hoefling, Housler, Majewski, Ambrozaitis, Gilmore, Kleinhardt, Fancon and Haskell
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (0)
   Motion carried

   It was moved by Commissioner Housler, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to accept the Contract from the Michigan Department of Transportation- Office of Aeronautics Fiscal Recovery Funds for Crack Seal and Paint Marking at the Airport, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (7) being Commissioners Housler, Hoefling, Majewski, Ambrozaitis, Kleinhardt, Fancon and Haskell
   Nays: (2) being Commissioners Pitchford and Gilmore
   Absent: (0)
   Motion carried

2. Equalization
   It was moved by Commissioner Ambrozaitis, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to approve the L-4029 2025 Tax Rate reflective of a millage rollback in the amount of $1,476,346,341, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (9) being Commissioners Ambrozaitis, Hoefling, Pitchford, Majewski, Housler, Gilmore, Kleinhardt, Fancon and Haskell
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (0)
   Motion carried

PHYSICAL RESOURCES AND ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT - continued

3. EV Charging Station
   It was moved by Commissioner Gilmore, seconded by Commissioner Majewski to approve the Charging Station Agreement between Charge EV, LLV and Clare County as amended by our attorney, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (9) being Commissioners Gilmore, Majewski, Pitchford, Hoefling, Ambrozaitis, Housler, Kleinhardt, Fancon and Haskell
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (0)
   Motion carried

4. Hayes Township Code Enforcement
   It was moved by Commissioner Kleinhardt, seconded by Commissioner Ambrozaitis to approve the contract between Hayes Township and Community Development as amended by our attorney for the enforcement of blight, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (9) being Commissioners Kleinhardt, Ambrozaitis, Pitchford, Majewski, Hoefling, Gilmore, Housler, Fancon and Haskell
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (0)
   Motion carried

FINANCE AND ADMINISTRATION

1. Statutory Finance Committee
   It was moved by Commissioner Fancon, seconded by Commissioner Ambrozaitis to approve Statutory Finance Committee meeting minutes of May 13, 2024 in the amount of $71,691.78 and the amended minutes of April 29, 2024 in the amount of $162,051.60, the minutes of May 28, 2024 in the amount of $38,699.62 and minutes of June 10, 2024 in the amount of $206,776.17, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (9) being Commissioners Fancon, Ambrozaitis, Pitchford, Majewski, Hoefling, Gilmore, Kleinhardt, Housler and Haskell
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (0)
   Motion carried

2. Monthly Expenditures
   It was moved by Commissioner Housler, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to approve the expenditures for the month of May 2024 in the amount of $2,608,579.68 with the General Fund expenditures totaling $1,063,461.69, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (9) being Commissioners Housler, Hoefling, Pitchford, Majewski, Ambrozaitis, Kleinhardt, Fancon, Gilmore and Haskell
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (0)
   Motion carried

3. Policy Approval
   It was moved by Commissioner Housler, seconded by Commissioner Gilmore to approve the Courthouse Weapons Policy as presented, after discussion, **motion carried**.

FINANCE AND ADMINISTRATION - continued

4. Conservation District Lease
   It was moved by Commissioner Hoefling, seconded by Commissioner Majewski to approve a 99 year Lease Agreement with the Conservation District for property located in Hatton Township in the amount of $1.00 per year, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (9) being Commissioners Hoefling, Majewski, Pitchford, Housler, Ambrozaitis, Gilmore, Kleinhardt, Fancon and Haskell
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (0)
   Motion carried

CLERK/REGISTER OF DEEDS REPORT

Clerk and Register of Deeds Lori Mott gave an update regarding the 55th Circuit Court, Register of Deeds and Elections.

TREASURER'S REPORT

Treasurer Jenny Beemer-Fritzinger provided all the statutory reports to the Commissioners.

CHAIRMAN'S REPORT

Chairman Jeff Haskell had no report.

VICE CHAIRMAN'S REPORT

Vice Chairman Dale Majewski reminded everyone this is the weekend for the expo in Lincoln Township from 11:00 – 3:00.

COMMISSIONER'S REPORT

Commissioner Housler gave an update on Freeman Township.

Commissioner Hoefling reported that some of his townships are working on improvements.

Commissioner Pitchford has attended her meetings and cautioned the other Commissioners to stop spending money.

Commissioner Ambrozaitis gave an update on the meetings he attended and agreed to put together a presentation on the airport so everyone has a full understanding of facility/grounds.

Commissioner Gilmore attended his meetings.

Commissioner Kleinhardt went to the Michigan Association of Counties meeting and reported on a septic tank inspection law that is going to be passed and solar energy.

Commissioner Fancon had no report

STATE OF THE COUNTY BUDGET

Chairman Haskell feels that Clare County is in good shape because of the proactive steps being taken by the elected officials, department heads and Administrator.

PUBLIC COMMENT

Pat Adams announced that he has gotten hearing aids but still is having a very difficult time hearing during the meeting and asked for an update on the microphone system being installed that he has asked for on multiple occasions. Administrator Phelps confirmed that she is just waiting on the company to come and install and there is no proposed update on a timeframe for installation.

Mr. Adams also asked the Board of Commissioners to unite and do what is best for the county as a whole and not just what is best for their individual townships.

Administrator Phelps announced that MMR (Mobile Medical Response) is hosting First on the Scene trainings, free of charge.

Lisa Ashley gave a report regarding the Recovery Court and Veterans Treatment Court.

Citizens spoke again about the community involvement on improving the airport and thanked the Board of Commissioners for the two appropriations they did give to the airport and talked about the positive impact on children, businesses and the tax base that could be made by supporting the airport.

UNFINISHED BUSINESS

None

NEW BUSINESS

None

Meeting Adjourned at 11:26 a.m.

Lori Mott, Clerk
Clare County Board of Commissioners

Jeff Haskell, Chairman
Clare County Board of Commissioners